# Research Methods for PMs

Session 03 · Class 2 · Arun Nandewal · 20 Jul 2026

> Research exists to kill your assumptions, not confirm them. Read your own data first, form a hypothesis, then ask one question sharp enough that a bad answer ends the project.

## AT A GLANCE

- Seven types of PM research: user, market, competitor, customer, technical, product-market fit, financial viability.
- Everything splits into **primary** (you generated it) and **secondary** (it already exists). Secondary always goes first.
- Needs are what users say. Behaviour is what users do. When the two disagree, the logs are true.
- Qualitative answers *why* from 5–10 people. Quantitative answers *how many* from hundreds to millions.
- Know the output you want before you open your mouth. Microsoft Excel PMs get two questions per user, twice a year.
- How and whom you ask matters more than what you ask. Research that no answer could invalidate is a rubber stamp, not research.

## CORE CONCEPTS

### What user research actually is

The systematic study of target users and their requirements, to add realistic context to the design process. **Systematic** means a method and a defined output, not three friends over coffee. **Target** means you decided in advance who counts as a user.

### Needs versus behaviour

You launch PhonePe UPI Lite. A friend says “raise the no-PIN cap from ₹2,000 to ₹5,000” — clean, writable as a ticket. Then you open analytics: he has never used UPI Lite once. Friendly people hand you requirements for products they never touch. Believe the logs.

### Secondary research comes first

Myntra data shows Tier 1 women opening the app between 6 and 7 PM, in cabs on the commute home. They scroll; they rarely buy. Asking “what would make you purchase instantly?” produces clean data and a wrong conclusion. Data picks the cohort; the cohort decides the question.

## CORE CONCEPTS, CONTINUED

### Primary versus secondary

Primary is first-hand data nobody else holds: interviews, surveys, focus groups, usability tests, observation, your own A/B tests and analytics. Secondary already exists: market and industry reports, competitor teardowns, app store reviews, academic papers, government data. The same method can be either — your A/B results are primary; Amazon's published A/B findings, read by Flipkart, are secondary for Flipkart.

### Know the output before you ask

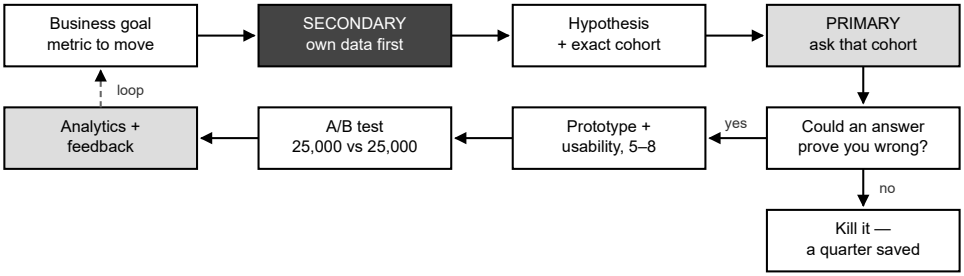
Microsoft Excel has roughly 1.2 billion monthly users and a PM team of about 25. Twice a year Microsoft flies in the world's top 20 power users. Each PM gets 30 minutes and **two questions** — four questions a year with the best users alive. Access is rationed. Name the decision the answer will inform, or do not ask.

### Wording decides the answer

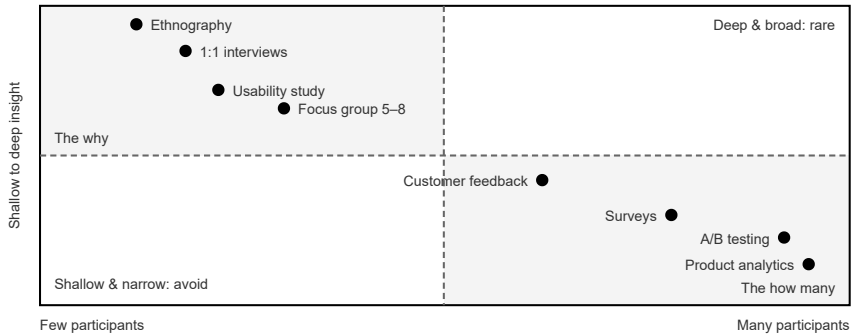
"Meeting a stranger, dating them, and exploring *a life* with them" is Shaadi.com. Change three words to "exploring *something fun*" and it is Tinder. Arun merged both by going open: "what are you looking for?" — networking, dating, flings, marriage. Those options are what Bumble shipped as BFF and Bizz. Question design and product architecture answer the same question.

## QUALITATIVE VS QUANTITATIVE

| | Qualitative | Quantitative |
|---|---|---|
| **Answers** | Why? How? | How many? Did it move? |
| **Sample** | 5–10 people | Hundreds to millions |
| **Methods** | 1:1 interviews, ethnography, usability tests, focus groups | Surveys, A/B tests, product analytics |
| **Strength** | Depth; finds what you never thought to ask | Statistical confidence; trend detection |
| **Weakness** | Cannot generalise | What changed, never why |
| **Use to** | Generate hypotheses, explore, build personas | Validate, measure impact, price, prioritise |
| **Example** | Apple interviewing users before an iPhone launch | Tesla reading Autopilot data over millions of miles |




The order is the lesson. Your own data narrows the cohort; primary research earns the right to build. If no possible answer sends you down the kill branch, you designed a rubber stamp.




Cheap and broad tells you how many; expensive and narrow tells you why. A research plan uses both shaded corners, because a number convinces the executive and a quote tells the designer what to build.

## EXAMPLES FROM CLASS

- **Google Maps, Sarjapur** — ambulance routed to the main gate: 3 km detour, 30 minutes, permanent paralysis, a court case. The PM got two questions.
- **PhonePe UPI Lite** — a friend asked to raise the no-PIN cap from ₹2,000 to ₹5,000. Analytics: he had never opened the feature.
- **Microsoft Copilot** — users hunted for it in the app search bar and typed “copilot” into Excel cells. It worked; nobody could find it.
- **MakeMyTrip visas** — a generic opening question cast the room, then ten users were split five and five by dominance and the session run twice.
- **Google Glass** — researched only with tech enthusiasts, who all said buy. Adoption arrived; retention never did. Judge on week four.
- **Amazon** — students opened the same iPhone 17 Pro page at the same moment and saw EMI, price and discount in different positions.

## TRAPS TO AVOID

FIVE WAYS GOOD RESEARCH GOES WRONG

- Asking users to design the product. They will ask for your salary.
- Leading questions — praise the thing, then ask whether they like it.
- Asking for data you already own, or data you have not earned.
- Believing a friendly user with two sessions this month.
- Confusing adoption with retention, or "cannot find it" with "does not want it".

## WHAT THE INSTRUCTOR STRESSED

- Know the output you want before you ask. He said it four separate times.
- Secondary first: data, then behaviour, then segment, then talk.
- Design one question that could prove you wrong. 80% saying "no concerns" is a win.
- Your bias is invisible to you and feels exactly like common sense.

## PRACTICE

- [ ] Write three Maps emergency-routing questions; one must kill the idea.
- [ ] Rewrite five bad questions so each passes all six checks.
- [ ] Rebuild the qual/quant and primary/secondary grid from memory.
- [ ] Ask three people what happens if this app vanishes tomorrow. Record verbatim.
- [ ] Spend 90 minutes on secondary research for one app you use daily.

## GLOSSARY

**Primary research** — data you generate; nobody else has it.

**Secondary research** — data that already exists. Step one.

**Qualitative** — text and observation, 5–10 people, answers why.

**Quantitative** — numbers at scale, answers how many.

**Hypothesis** — a testable belief a result could disprove.

**Invalidation** — an answer that would kill your idea.

**Leading question** — one that pre-loads its own answer.

**Escape hatch** — the "reason not listed" option.

**Cohort flip** — swap groups mid A/B test to confirm.

**Substitution test** — "what if this vanished tomorrow?"

**Mom Test** — ask so a kind liar cannot lie.

**Discoverability** — can users find a feature that exists.